

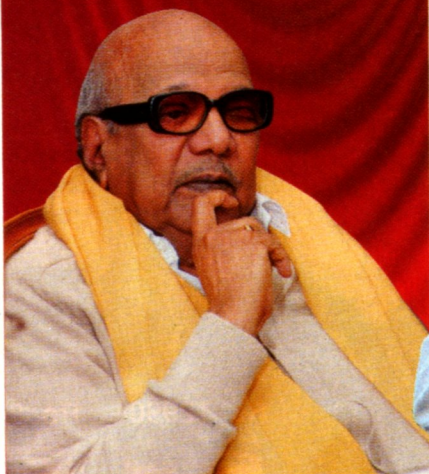
POLL PANIC M. KARUNANIDHI

"I am in constant touch with Sonia Gandhi as well as the Left parties. The UPA Government will not change its path. This is a promise."

AUGUST 20, 2007

"Frankly the deal is not important, the Government is. I did have doubts about the deal. I spoke to the Left and fought for the Left."

OCTOBER 15, 2007



SIPRA DAS

LALU PRASAD

"Remember we are a country of 1.1 billion people. No one can bully us. We cannot be lethargic out of fear. We must proceed."

AUGUST 25, 2007

"No party wants a snap poll as it is not in the interest of the nation. The Government will not fall and there is no possibility of mid-term polls."

OCTOBER 9, 2007



BANDEEP SINGH

SHARAD PAWAR

"I am not sure there will be mid-term polls. The Left parties have some concerns over the deal, but it is our duty to dispel their doubts."

SEPTEMBER 22, 2007

"It's a good deal but we all must remember that it is a coalition Government where allies and partners' feelings must be considered."

OCTOBER 12, 2007



RAVI S SAHANI

control India's foreign policy". In Delhi, the monsoon session of the Parliament was punctuated by constant disruptions. Thanks to these, the Congress did not have to engage all parties in a futile debate over an agreement which, in the first place, did not require parliamentary ratification.

The Congress then thought it could make the Left turn around. A symbolic "joint mechanism" to study the Left's concerns vis-à-vis the agreement would not harm either side. Making Water Resources Minister Saifuddin Soz a member of the coordination committee was an instance of the Congress's compulsive tokenism. The political panel was inaugurated at Congress troubleshooter Mukherjee's residence on September 14 over tea and biscuits. After three subsequent meetings where nine notes were

exchanged between the two sides, no breakthrough was in sight. For every argument of the Government, there was a counter-argument from the Left.

Mukherjee faltered in his negotiations and Manmohan told Sonia in the first week of October that the nuclear time table would go topsy-turvy if he did not apply for the safeguards agreement at IAEA. Sonia then informed Karat and Yechury that her Government would go ahead with the deal. Karat's response was not surprising: they would withdraw support. Manmohan withdrew before that. Is the agreement dead? And what happens if the Congress tries to revive the process after the Gujarat elections in December? "Our position will remain unaltered," Karat told INDIA TODAY.

Certainly it will. The Indian communist's position has remained unaltered in spite of such severe

alterations in history. That line, ideally, should have come from Manmohan. To his middle class fan club, he is a man of not some rusty ideology but redeeming ideas. All other chief protagonists of the deal proved to be of steely conviction—Karat, no matter how dogmatic he is, and Bush, who stood by India despite the powerful liberal establishment's opposition to a deal that went against the ideals of non-proliferation. Manmohan has become the odd man out—a man nobody knows what he believes in. His maiden speech as finance minister had the inspiring quote from Victor Hugo: "No power on earth can stop an idea whose time has come." That could have been the motto of an action hero with a value system. As prime minister, he has been feted at home and abroad as a quiet moderator with a modernising spirit. Today the Great Hope of 21st-century India has become the Big Let-down. ■